What We Know, What We've Been Told, What's Still Open

A worksheet for Mom's situation, one area at a time.

“My cousin heard that someone from the facility would call about the paperwork” is something you were told. “The admission agreement is in the blue folder” is something you know. Late at night they feel the same, and they aren't.

Take each area below in turn and start every line with Know, Told or Open. Know means you have a paper, or the person responsible said so. Told means someone said it; write who. Open means nobody has answered it yet.

Put your name and today's date at the top. Don't rank the areas and don't try to solve anything here. Whether something stands between Mom and Medicaid is for a professional who knows your state's rules to say.

Mom's care

Where she is now, what help she gets there, and what anyone has said about what comes next.

FOR EXAMPLE Know: she has been on the second floor since the move, and the notes from the care meeting are in the folder. Told: my sister heard from an aide that she needs help with most daily tasks now. Open: nobody has said how long this level of care is expected.

Income

What comes in each month and where it comes from, as far as you can tell. Round numbers are fine, and so is a blank.

FOR EXAMPLE Know: her Social Security goes into the checking account; it's on the bank statement. Told: Dad's old employer may still pay a pension (my aunt). Open: is the pension still coming, and into which account?

What she owns

Accounts, a home, a vehicle, insurance policies: what you know exists and whose name is on it. A list is enough. No totals are needed on this page.

FOR EXAMPLE Know: checking and savings at the same bank; we have both statements. Told: there is a life insurance policy "somewhere" (Mom). Open: whose name is on the deed to the house?

Money or property that has changed hands

Gifts, sales, or anything put into someone else's name that you know of: what it was and roughly when. Just write it down. What it means, if anything, is a question for your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney.

FOR EXAMPLE Know: Mom sold her car last spring; the bill of sale is in the folder. Told: she helped my brother with a down payment some years back (my sister). Open: when was that, and is there any paperwork?

Documents

The papers you have in hand, the ones you know exist but can't find, and the ones someone has asked you for.

FOR EXAMPLE Know: the admission agreement and the most recent facility statements are in the blue folder. Told: my brother says the business office wants "bank records"; he didn't hear which. Open: which records, and from when?

Legal papers

Which legal papers you know Mom has signed, where the originals are, and who has copies. Write what the cover page says, not what you think it allows.

FOR EXAMPLE Know: there is a folder from a law office in her desk; nobody has opened it. Told: my brother says he can sign for her. Open: which paper says so, and where is it?

What this shows you

Three things in each area: what you can point to, what is only something you were told so far, and what nobody has answered. It doesn't show whether anything stands in the way of Medicaid, and nothing here adds up to a score or a level. Which open items matter, and what happens about them, belongs to the planning conversation with a professional who knows your state's rules. Nothing on this page is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You've separated what you know from what you've been told, one area at a time. The planning interview picks up from there: it asks about Mom's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for her care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›